

BHASKAR PAUL

rup, screenplay writer Simon Beaufoy, editor Chris Dickens, actor Anil Kapoor, sound mixer Resul Pookutty, 20th Century Fox CEO Stephen Gilula, Fox Star
n, actors Ayush Khedekar, Tanay Chheda, Tanvi Lonkar, Ashutosh Lobo Gajiwala, Freida Pinto, Madhur Mittal, Dev Patel and his mother Anita Patel

ERS

First class upgrades. Stretch limos. Free couture from neon-lit designers. Celebrity chat show appearances. Four Golden Globes, seven BAFTAs and 10 Oscar nominations. Poverty porn or just a very smart movie in a depressing year, *Slumdog Millionaire*'s fantastic ride looks all set to continue.

brightest smiles, he says. Kapoor, speaking of lunching with Clint Eastwood at Los Angeles' fine diner The Grill, sounds as if he'd like to pinch himself. Irrfan, till now a fairly cynical veteran of many international projects, is thunderstruck. "It's a wave. Everyone has to go and watch it." "It's unbelievable," agrees co-director Loveleen Tandan, as she plans on wearing red to the red carpet at Los Angeles' Kodak Theatre next week. "I'm not in the mood to be subtle."

Neither is the movie. It is the ultimate Bollywood formula, complete with feuding brothers, long lost love, boys tumbling down a train and growing up by several years. Its making was also not easy. Boyle struggled with the casting of the little boys and girl, concealing that their roles were to be done in Hindi from the producers. He got cancelled on seven times by Shah Rukh Khan, whom he wanted to play the role that went to Kapoor. Amitabh Bachchan refused to play himself. And every time Boyle would go to a location after a recce, its topography would change. The result of this coordinated anarchy has grabbed viewers across the world. "Fantastic," says Yash Chopra, even while he admits to feeling squeamish about the shit scene. "Outstanding," says Kashyap, "it keeps you on your toes."

It's this quality that grabbed acquisitions editor Jane Lawson at Transworld/Random House when the *Q&A* manuscript landed at her desk in 2004. "It was an easy pitch. It's the story of a penniless orphan who wins *Who Wants to be a Millionaire*." Film Four bought the rights even before the book was published, and by the time Simon Beaufoy adapted it, it had been sold in 35 countries and had become a bestseller in Israel, Germany and Spain.

The question now is that while it has got more publicity than money can buy for Indian talent, can Bollywood become a global industry? The signs are there. Indian money is much in demand with the DreamWorks deal now set at $325 million from Reliance ADAG. Hollywood is looking at basing more movies in India, whether it is Julia Roberts planning part of *Eat Pray Love* here or Peter Weir tracing the journey of eight prisoners from a Russian gulag who pass through in *The Way Back*. It's like two big cats sizing each other, says Boyle, of Hollywood and Bollywood. "They're bound to come together." Going by what he's made happen with this movie, it would be wise not to disbelieve him.